

# "HANSEATIC ROUTES BENEATH THE GERMAN BIGHT"

## The German Bight as a Maritime Landscape

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Draft date: 28.01.2026 | Not for circulation

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### 1.1 Introduction: A Sea Between Two Worlds

The German Bight is a maritime world that keeps its secrets badly. The water is shallow, the light is grey, and the silt that drifts across the seabed records every disturbance. Fishermen have known for generations that the outer Wattenmeer hides things: the timbers that come up in their nets, the iron concretions that bend their winches, the ceramic sherds that litter the sites their fathers' fathers called by names no longer on any chart. What the Bight does less willingly is give up the full story of what lies beneath it.

That story is a Hanseatic one. Between roughly 1250 and 1550, the North Sea was the arterial system of a commercial network that connected Hamburg, Lubeck, and Bremen in the east to London, Bruges, and Bergen in the west and north, and that channelled the wool, grain, fish, wine, and manufactured goods on which northern European urban economies depended. The German Bight was not the periphery of this network. It was the crossing point between the Baltic approaches and the western routes, the zone through which the eastbound and westbound traffic of the Hanse was funnelled each season.

The wrecks that lie in the Bight's shallow waters are the physical remains of that traffic. A ship lost at 12 metres in the outer Wattenmeer in the 14th century was not a marginal vessel at the edge of the known world. It was almost certainly a vessel actively engaged in the core commerce of its age, carrying a cargo that had been assessed, taxed, and documented at a Hamburg or Lubeck toll point before it sailed. That documentation, where it survives, is in the archives. The ship itself is in the sea. The goal of the North Frisian Survey is to bring those two bodies of evidence into the same analytical frame.

### 1.2 Physical Geography of the German Bight

The German Bight is the southeastern corner of the North Sea, bounded to the north by the coast of Jutland, to the east by the German and Danish coasts, and to the west by the open North Sea. It is a shallow, tide-dominated shelf sea. Water depths across the core of the Bight rarely exceed 30 metres, and the Wadden Sea tidal flats that fringe the German coast to the Jutland peninsula extend the shallow zone to the north and north-west.

Tidal range is significant: spring tides in the inner Bight reach 3.5 metres or more, generating tidal currents that, at their peak, can transport sediment actively across the seabed. The tidal residual transport moves sediment broadly in a clockwise direction around the Bight, from the estuaries eastward along the northern Wadden Sea and out into the deeper central North Sea. This transport regime is directly relevant to the preservation and exposure of wreck material: buried sites may be gradually uncovered by the migration of sand banks, while newly exposed material may be carried off the site and redistributed.

The barrier island system of the North Frisian and East Frisian islands defines the outer boundary of the Wadden Sea. These islands are themselves dynamic geological features, their positions and extents modified continuously by longshore drift and storm impact. In the medieval period, the coastline configuration was substantially different from today. The catastrophic storm floods of 1362 and 1634, documented extensively in Frisian historical sources, reshaped the coastal zone dramatically, drowning significant areas of settled agricultural land and shifting the navigational channels used by Hanseatic vessels.

### **1.3 The Hanseatic Trade Network in the German Bight**

The Hanseatic League was not a state and not a fixed institution. It was a loose association of merchant communities and towns that shared commercial interests, maintained common standards for weights and measures in certain commodities, and acted collectively to protect commercial privileges in foreign markets. At its core were the great north German port cities: Hamburg, Lubeck, and Bremen. Hamburg's position at the mouth of the Elbe, connecting the North Sea directly to the central European river system, made it the key node for east-west and north-south exchange throughout the Hanseatic period.

The commodities that defined the Hanseatic trade flowing through the German Bight in the 14th century were concentrated in a small number of high-volume, low-value categories: dried and salted fish from the Scandinavian and Baltic coasts; grain from the east Elbian agricultural hinterland; Flemish and English cloth; Rhineland wine; and the salt from Luneburg that preserved the fish and the meat that fed the urban populations of the north. These were not luxury goods. They were necessities, and the ships that carried them were working vessels designed for volume and reliability, not speed or elegance.

The ship type most closely associated with this trade in the 14th century is the cog: a clinker-built, single-masted, flat-bottomed vessel capable of navigating the shallow estuaries and tidal channels of the German Bight coast while carrying substantial cargo. The clinker construction, in which planks are overlapped and fastened with iron nails, is characteristic of the northern European shipbuilding tradition and produces the distinctive acoustic and visual signature that makes Hanseatic wrecks identifiable in archaeological survey data.

Site NF-7 fits this profile closely. The clinker construction confirmed by the Phase 3 finds, the ceramic assemblage consistent with Hanseatic trade goods, and the depth and location of the site at the edge of the North Frisian navigation channel all point to a vessel of the working merchant type, engaged in the routine commerce that sustained the Hanseatic network in the middle decades of the 14th century.

### **1.4 The Archaeological Record in the German Bight**

The underwater archaeology of the German Bight is in its earliest systematic phase. The region was extensively surveyed by the commercial sector in the 20th century for hydrographic and infrastructure purposes, and these surveys produced the baseline remote sensing data on which most current archaeological work depends. However, the research questions informing commercial survey are different from those informing archaeological survey: commercial datasets were not collected with the resolution or the analytical framework necessary for routine archaeological feature identification.

The published archaeological literature for the German Bight includes a small number of significant sites: the Kolding shipwreck investigations off the Danish coast, the Bremerhaven medieval wreck investigations, and the ongoing work of the Lower Saxon State Office for Cultural Heritage in the East Frisian waters. The North Frisian Survey extends this work northward into Schleswig-Holstein waters and applies the most current MBES methodology to a region that had not previously been subject to systematic archaeological remote sensing.

The Frisian oral historical tradition, preserved through community transmission and now actively engaged through the survey's community consultation programme, contributes a layer of place-name and navigation knowledge that is not available from any archival source. The synthesis

of this oral evidence with archaeological survey data is one of the methodological innovations of the North Frisian Survey and is addressed in Chapter 5 of this monograph.